

What I Learned From 10 Years of MONEYLEAGUE Data

May 2026

I went down a rabbit hole and pulled all 10 years of our drafts out of the league spreadsheet (the cell colors tell you who actually owned each pick — even the Yahoo pick trades). Then I matched everything up against real NFL stats and looked at what wins. Here's the TL;DR for everyone before next year.

The biggest thing: peak-year draft > career-best draft

Every single champion in the Sleeper era — Eric (2023), Coop (2024), Trevor (2025) — was a **top-2 drafter that specific year**, even when their 3-year average wasn't elite. Meanwhile, the guy with the best 3-year average hasn't won.

Translation: it doesn't matter if you're a "good drafter" in the abstract. What matters is **nailed the one year you want to win**. Don't get cute, don't overthink your keepers, draft BPA, balance positions. That's it.

The wire is way more important than most of us treat it

Look at the league-winners that came off the wire in the last 3 years:

- **Rico Dowdle** (RB) — picked up W5 of 2025, +176 pts after the add
- **Russell Wilson** (QB) — picked up W7 of 2024, +166 pts after the add
- **Gardner Minshew** (QB) — picked up W5 of 2023, +166 pts after the add
- **Darnell Mooney** (WR) — picked up W2 of 2024, +159 pts after the add
- **Adam Thielen** (WR) — picked up W2 of 2023, +158 pts after the add

These aren't random. They follow a pattern. Every year, around Week 2-3 a workhorse RB gets hurt and his handcuff becomes a league-winner. Around Week 7-10 a starting QB gets benched or hurt and a backup takes over. Around Week 10 the trade deadline causes a wave of drops as people clear playoff roster space.

If you're checking the wire once a week and only on Tuesday morning, you're missing 80% of these.

Stop overweighting WR and TE adds

Across the last 3 years, the average WR or TE wire pickup produced about **20 pts** — basically a wasted roster spot. The average QB pickup produced **48**. The average RB pickup produced **28**.

Most of us (me included) add too many "that WR3 had a good Sunday" guys. They almost never repeat. If you're picking up a WR, it should be a rookie with a target-share spike or someone moving up an injury depth chart — not a TD-vulture veteran.

Don't trade unless you're robbing someone

Trade wins and losses across the league sum to zero by math. Most trades are coin flips. The successful trades in our league all had the same shape: **the buyer was getting clearly more VBD than they were giving up**, not just "a different type of player."

Side note: **future picks are wildly underpriced** in our league. People keep accepting 1 current-year R5 for a future R2. The future R2 is worth more, every time. Stop doing this.

If you had a bad season but lots of points, you got schedule-killed

Compare points-for to wins. If your PF was high but your record was bad, you got unlucky and you're due. If your PF was low but your record was good, you got lucky and you're going to regress. This is real — the

unluckiest manager of 2023-25 was beating the league in scoring most weeks. Just got the wrong opponent each week.

Don't blow up your roster after a 1-3 start if the points are there. **Roster quality is a leading indicator, record is a lagging one.**

Kickers are free money in the late rounds

Top kicker hits in our 3-year window:

- Brandon Aubrey (drafted R15) — +141 pts above replacement
- Chris Boswell (drafted R16) — +155 pts above replacement
- Evan McPherson (drafted R16) — +137 pts above replacement
- Ka'imi Fairbairn (R16) — +143 pts above replacement

Those are R2-level returns from R15 picks. Almost nobody does any kicker research. If you spent 10 minutes ranking kickers by FG% and dome stadiums in August, you'd find an extra ~100 VBD per year. Easy edge.

TL;DR — six things to do differently

1. **Draft BPA.** Don't engineer your draft around your keepers. Best player available wins.
2. **Check the wire 3× a week, not 1×.** Sunday night and Monday after games is where the wire-winners get claimed.
3. **Stop adding marginal WRs and TEs.** Add QBs and RBs first, in that order.
4. **Trade rarely, trade only when clearly winning, and stop accepting current-year picks for future picks.**
5. **Trust regression.** Bad record + high points = next year is yours. Good record + low points = enjoy this year, next year hurts.
6. **Research kickers.** It's the dumbest, most reliable edge in the league.

Full nerdy version (with tables and percentiles) available if anyone wants it. Numbers in here come from the league spreadsheet's draft history plus

public NFL stats — happy to share the underlying data with anyone who wants to verify.